on the rest—a method that will lead not back to a golden age but to certain disaster.

THE BJP AND HINDUTVA

Following Upadhyaya's death and its rout in the elections of 1971, the Bharatiya Jana Sangh merged in 1977 into the Janata Party, which was born from the resistance of all Opposition parties to Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's Emergency. But when the Janata Party won the national elections which followed, its internal contradictions soon surfaced. Foremost among these was the 'dual membership' issue, with many Janata Party members objecting to the continued involvement with the RSS of the former Bharatiya Jana Sangh politicians. The Janata Party split over RSS influence on its Sanghi elements, and the Bharatiya Jana Sangh members reconstituted themselves as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in 1980, vowing allegiance to 'Gandhian socialism' in an attempt to make themselves more appealing to the mainstream.

The experiment with moderate political messaging failed: the BJP won just two seats in India's 545-member Lok Sabha in 1984. Disillusioned with this unsuccessful attempt at seeking political respectability by tempering its core beliefs, the BJP remade itself into an explicitly Hindu party, stirring up Hindu sentiment.

The 1980s were a time of great ferment in Indian politics, with the Sikh separatist Khalistan movement at its peak, Assamese students rising in protest against Bangladeshi illegal immigrants who were transforming the demography of their state, Tamil separatism in neighbouring Sri Lanka drawing India into the maelstrom and a youthful but Westernised prime minister, Rajiv Gandhi, seemingly running the country from a great height, like the airline pilot he had once been. The BJP sensed an opportunity to carve out a distinctive space for itself as a defender of Hindu interests. In a resolution adopted officially at Palampur in 1989, it declared Hindutva as its ideology—while claiming that Hindutva represents 'cultural nationalism' and embodies 'Indian nationhood,' rather than a religious or theological concept. In the years following, the BJP established a distinctive Hindutva agenda in national politics, advocating 'Hindu' causes—some which manifestly went beyond